

The text is from the second edition of Mather's *Magnalia Christi Americana; or, The Ecclesiastical History of New England*, ed. Thomas Robbins, 2 vols. (Hartford, 1853), I, 118-31 (book two). I have noted any significant variations from the first edition (London, 1702). In modernizing the text, I have (a) deleted the citations in Greek (noting where I did so), since Mather himself generally translates these in the text into both Latin and English; (b) changed punctuation and paragraphing in a few cases; and (c) omitted Mather's frequent use of italics and capitalization, and his numbering of paragraphs. I am aware that some of these devices reflect seventeenth-century rules of logic and rhetoric as well as modes of pulpit exhortation. But the fact remains that they now hinder comprehension, and my aim is to offer a readable and readily accessible text. I am indebted to the annotations to the Life of Winthrop in K. B. Murdock's edition of *Selections from Cotton Mather* (New York, 1960), and in G. E. McCandlish's Harvard dissertation, 1963; the annotations here, however, are wholly my own.

Nehemias Americanus. The Life of John Winthrop, Esq., Governor of the Massachusetts Colony

Quincunque venti erunt, ars nostra certe non aberit. CICERO¹

Let Greece boast of her patient Lycurgus,² the lawgiver, by whom diligence, temperance, fortitude and wit were made the fashions of a therefore long-lasting and renowned commonwealth; let Rome tell of her devout Numa,³ the lawgiver, by whom the most famous commonwealth saw peace triumphing over extinguished war, and cruel plunders and murders giving place to the more mollifying exercises of his religion. Our

1. "Whatever winds may blow, our art will surely never pass away." Cicero *Epistulae ad Familiares* 12.25.5.

2. According to tradition, the great reformer of the Spartan Constitution (7th century B.C.). His "criminal disorders" may refer to the war machine Lycurgus is said to have built to prevent trouble with the Helots; more likely the reference is to the uprisings of the wealthy citizens deprived by Lycurgus of their wealth.

3. Numa Pompilius: legendary king of Rome after Romulus; supposedly authored the Roman ceremonial law; his "heathenish madness" probably refers to his supposed adherence to the doctrines of Pythagoras.

New England shall tell and boast of her Winthrop, a lawgiver as patient as Lycurgus, but not admitting any of his criminal disorders; as devout as Numa, but not liable to any of his heathenish madnenses; a governor in whom the excellencies of Christianity made a most improving addition unto the virtues, wherein even without those he would have made a parallel for the great men of Greece or of Rome, which the pen of a Plutarch has eternized.

A stock of heroes by right should afford nothing but what is heroical, and nothing but an extreme degeneracy would make anything less to be expected from a stock of Winthrops. Mr. Adam Winthrop, the son of a worthy gentleman wearing the same name, was himself a worthy, a discreet, and a learned gentleman, particularly eminent for skill in the law, nor without remark for love to the Gospel, under the reign of King Henry VIII; and brother to a memorable favorer of the Reformed religion in the days of Queen Mary, into whose hands the famous martyr Philpot⁴ committed his papers, which afterwards made no inconsiderable part of our martyr-books. This Mr. Adam Winthrop had a son of the same name also, and of the same endowments and employments with his father; and this third Adam Winthrop was the father of that renowned John Winthrop who was the father of New England and the founder of a colony which, upon many accounts, like him that founded it, may challenge the first place among the English glories of America. Our John Winthrop, thus born at the mansion-house of his ancestors, at Groton in Suffolk, on June 12, 1587,⁵ enjoyed afterwards an agreeable education. But though he would rather have devoted himself unto the study of Mr. John Calvin than of Sir Edward Cook,⁶ nevertheless the accomplishments of a lawyer were those wherewith heaven made his chief opportunities to be serviceable.

Being made at the unusually early age of eighteen a Justice of Peace, his virtues began to fall under a more general observation; and he not only so bound himself to the behavior of a Christian as to become exemplary for a conformity to the laws of Christianity in his own conversation, but also discovered a more than ordinary measure of those qualities which adorn an officer of humane society. His justice was impartial, and used the balance to weigh not the cash but the case of those who were before him:

4. John Philpot (1516–1555), Archdeacon of Winchester; early Puritan martyr, burned at the stake; memorialized in John Foxe's *Book of Martyrs*. The references below to Winthrop's lineage are to Adam Winthrop, grandfather (1498–1562); Adam Winthrop, father (1548–1623); and William Winthrop, uncle (1529–82).

5. Should read January 12, 1583.

6. Or Coke (1552–1634); Lord-Chief-Justice and compiler of the authoritative *Institutes of English Law*; Mather's reference to Winthrop's early plans to enter the ministry implicitly juxtaposes Calvin's *Institutes* with Coke's.

prosopolatria he reckoned as bad as *idolatry*.⁷ His wisdom did exquisitely temper things according to the art of governing, which is a business of more contrivance than the seven arts of the schools:⁸ *oyer* still went before *terminer*⁹ in all his administrations. His courage made him dare to do right, and fitted him to stand among the lions that have sometimes been the supporters of the throne.¹⁰ All which virtues he rendered the more illustrious by emblazoning them with the constant liberality and hospitality of a gentleman. This made him the terror of the wicked and the delight of the sober, the envy of the many but the hope of those who had any hopeful design in hand for the common good of the nation and the interests of religion.

Accordingly, when the noble design of carrying a colony of chosen people into an American wilderness was by some eminent persons undertaken, this eminent person was, by the consent of all, chosen for the Moses who must be the leader of so great an undertaking. And indeed nothing but a Mosaic spirit could have carried him through the temptations to which either his farewell to his own land or his travel in a strange land must needs expose a gentleman of his education. Wherefore, having sold a fair estate of six or seven hundred a year, he transported himself with the effects of it into New England in the year 1630, where he spent it upon the service of a famous plantation founded and formed for the seat of the most reformed Christianity, and continued there conflicting with temptations of all sorts, as many years as the nodes of the moon take to dispatch a revolution.¹¹ Those persons were never concerned in a new plantation who know not that the unavoidable difficulties of such a thing will call for all the prudence and patience of a mortal man to encounter therewithal; and they must be very insensible of the influence which the just wrath of heaven has permitted the devils to have upon this world, if they do not think that the difficulties of a new plantation, devoted unto the evangelical worship of our Lord Jesus Christ, must be yet more than ordinary. How prudently, how patiently, and with how much resignation to our Lord Jesus Christ our brave Winthrop waded through these difficulties, let posterity consider with admiration. And know that as the

7. I.e., the worship of men is tantamount to idolatry; literally *prosopolatria* means "face-worship."

8. The trivium (grammar, rhetoric, logic) and the quadrivium (arithmetic, music, geometry, astronomy).

9. I.e., listened to all sides of the argument before judging the case; literally: "hearing" before "judging."

10. Solomon's throne was supported by lions on both sides (1 Kings 10 : 19-20, 2 Chron. 19 : 20-21); Daniel's faith saved him from the lions (Dan. 6 : 23).

11. I.e., 18.6 years.

picture of this their governor was, after his death, hung up with honor in the statehouse of his country, so the wisdom, courage, and holy zeal of his life were an example well worthy to be copied by all that shall succeed in government.

Were he now to be considered only as a Christian, we might therein propose him as greatly imitable. He was a very religious man; and as he strictly kept his heart, so he kept his house, under the laws of piety; there he was every day constant in holy duties, both morning and evening, and on the Lord's Days and lectures.¹² Though he wrote not after the preacher,¹³ yet such was his attention, and such his retention in hearing, that he repeated unto his family the sermons which he had heard in the congregation. But it is chiefly as a governor that he is now to be considered. Being the governor over the considerablest part of New England, he maintained the figure and honor of his place with the spirit of a true gentleman, but yet with such obliging condescension to the circumstances of the colony that when a certain troublesome and malicious calumniator, well known in those times, printed his libellous nicknames upon the chief persons here, the worst nickname he could find for the governor was John Temperwell.¹⁴ And when the calumnies of that ill man caused the Archbishop to summon one Mr. Cleaves¹⁵ before the King, in hopes to get some accusation from him against the country, Mr. Cleaves gave such an account of the governor's laudable carriage in all respects, and the serious devotion wherewith prayers were both publicly and privately made for his Majesty, that the King expressed himself most highly pleased therewithal, only sorry that so worthy a person should be no better accommodated than with the hardships of America.

He was, indeed, a governor who had most exactly studied that book which, pretending to teach politics, did only contain three leaves, and but one word in each of those leaves, which word was "Moderation." Hence, though he were a zealous enemy to all vice, yet his practice was according to his judgment thus expressed: "In the infancy of plantations, justice should be administered with more lenity than in a settled state, because people are more apt then to transgress, partly out of ignorance of new laws

12. 1 Tim. 3 : 4-5, Prov. 4 : 23, Deut. 11 : 18-19. Lectures were informal sermons.

13. Listeners sometimes recorded the sermon verbatim in shorthand.

14. Thomas Morton, *New-English Canaan* (London, 1637), part 4, chapter 23. Morton (ca. 1579-1649) was an adventurer and an Anglican who came into conflict with the Puritans on several occasions; the most famous of these was in 1628 at the settlement Morton founded at Mount Wollaston, or "Merry Mount" (now Quincy, Mass.).

15. George Cleaves settled at Richmond Island, Maine, in 1630, and returned briefly to England in 1636. He continued his associations with Morton until at least 1643. William Laud (1573-1645) was made Archbishop of Canterbury by Charles I in 1633.

and orders, partly out of oppression of business and other straits. *Lento gradu*¹⁶ was the old rule; and if the strings of a new instrument be wound up unto their height, they will quickly crack." But when some leading and learned men took offence at his conduct in this matter, and upon a conference gave it in as their opinion that a stricter discipline was to be used in the beginning of a plantation than after its being with more age established and confirmed, the governor, being readier to see his own errors than other men's, professed his purpose to endeavor their satisfaction with less of lenity in his administrations. At that conference there were drawn up several other articles to be observed between the governor and the rest of the magistrates, which were of this import: that the magistrates, as far as might be, should aforehand ripen their consultations, to produce that unanimity in their public votes which might make them liker to the voice of God; that if differences fell out among them in their public meetings, they should speak only to the case, without any reflection,¹⁷ with all due modesty, and but by way of question, or desire the deferring of the cause to further time, and after sentence to intimate privately no dislike; that they should be more familiar, friendly, and open unto each other, and more frequent in their visitations, and not any way expose each others' infirmities, but seek the honor of each other and all the court; that one magistrate shall not cross the proceedings of another without first advising with him; and that they should in all their appearances abroad be so circumstanced as to prevent all contempt of authority; and that they should support and strengthen all under-officers; all of which articles were observed by no man more than by the governor himself.

But whilst he thus did as our New English Nehemiah the part of a ruler in managing the public affairs of our American Jerusalem, when there were Tobijahs and Sanballats¹⁸ enough to vex him and give him the experiment of Luther's observation, "Omnis qui regit est tanquam signum, in quod omnia jacula Satan et mundus dirigunt,"¹⁹ he made himself still an exacter parallel unto that governor of Israel by doing the part of a neighbor among the distressed people of the new plantation. To teach them the frugality necessary for those times he abridged himself of a thousand comfortable things which he had allowed himself elsewhere. His habit was not that "soft raiment" which would have been disagreeable to a wilderness;²⁰ his table was not covered with the superfluities that would

16. "By slow degrees."

17. I.e., without "casting some imputation on a person" (N.E.D.).

18. Sanballat, governor of Samaria, and Tobijah, a Persian official, opposed the rebuilding of the walls of Jerusalem and later tried to depose Nehemiah (Neh. 2, 4, 6).

19. "All who rule are targets at which Satan and the world hurl their darts." (*Loci Communes*).

20. Matt. 11 : 8; Luke 7 : 25.

have invited unto sensualities: water was commonly his own drink, though he gave wine to others. But at the same time his liberality unto the needy was even beyond measure generous, and therein he was continually causing "the blessing of him that was ready to perish to come upon him, and the heart of the widow and the orphan to sing for joy"²¹—but none more than those of deceased ministers, whom he always treated with a very singular compassion, among the instances whereof we still enjoy with us the worthy and now aged son of that Reverend Higginson²² whose death left his family in a wide world soon after his arrival here, publicly acknowledging the charitable Winthrop for his foster father. It was oftentimes no small trial unto his faith to think "how a table for the people should be furnished when they first came into the wilderness!"²³ And for very many of the people his own good works were needful, and accordingly employed for the answering of his faith. Indeed, for a while the governor was the Joseph unto whom the whole body of the people repaired when their corn failed them.²⁴ And he continued relieving of them with his open-handed bounties as long as he had any stock to do it with; and a lively faith to see the return of the "bread after many days," and not starve in the days that were to pass till that return should be seen, carried him cheerfully through those expenses. Once it was observable that on February 5, 1630, when he was distributing the last handful of the "meal in the barrel" unto a poor man distressed by the wolf at the door, at that instant they spied a ship arrived at the harbor's mouth laden with provisions for them all.

Yea, the governor sometimes made his own private purse to be the public, not by sucking into it but by squeezing out of it; for when the public treasury had nothing in it, he did himself defray the charges of the public. And having learned that lesson of our Lord, that "it is better to give than to receive," he did, at the General Court, when he was a third time chosen governor, make a speech unto this purpose: that he had received gratuities from diverse towns, which he accepted with much comfort and content; and he had likewise received civilities from particular persons, which he could not refuse without incivility in himself; nevertheless, he took them with a trembling heart in regard of God's word

21. Job 29 : 13. Cf. Neh. 5 : 14–18, on Nehemiah's good deeds.

22. Francis Higginson (1587–1630), author of *New-Englands Plantation*, died a year after his arrival at Salem; his son, John (1616–1708), wrote a laudatory "Attestation" to Mather's *Magnalia*.

23. From David's psalm on the sins of the Exodus: "Yea, they spake against God; they said, Can God furnish a table in the wilderness?" (Ps. 78 : 19–20).

24. Gen. 41 : 56. The three following quotations are (respectively) from Eccles. 11 : 1, 1 Kings 17 : 2, and Acts 20 : 35 (altered).

and the conscience of his own infirmities, and therefore he desired them that they would not hereafter take it ill if he refused such presents for the time to come. 'Twas his custom also to send some of his family upon errands unto the houses of the poor about their mealtime, on purpose to spy whether they wanted; and if it were found that they wanted, he would make that the opportunity of sending supplies unto them. And there was one passage of his charity that was perhaps a little unusual. In an hard and long winter, when wood was very scarce at Boston, a man gave him a private information that a needy person in the neighborhood stole wood sometimes from his pile, whereupon the governor in a seeming anger did reply, "Does he so? I'll take a course with him; go, call that man to me, I'll warrant you I'll cure him of stealing!" When the man came, the governor, considering that if he had stolen it was more out of necessity than disposition, said unto him, "Friend, it is a severe winter, and I doubt you are but meanly provided for wood; wherefore I would have you supply yourself at my woodpile till this cold season be over." And he then merrily asked his friends whether he had not effectually cured this man of stealing his wood.

One would have imagined that so good a man could have had no enemies, if we had not had a daily and woeful experience to convince us that goodness itself will make enemies. It is a wonderful speech of Plato (in one of his books *de Republica*), "For the trial of true virtue, 'tis necessary that a good man, though he do no unjust thing, should suffer the infamy of the greatest injustice."²⁵ The governor had by his unspotted integrity procured himself a great reputation²⁶ among the people; and then the crime of popularity was laid unto his charge by such who were willing to deliver him from the danger of having "all men speak well of him." Yea, there were persons eminent both for figure and for number unto whom it was almost essential to dislike everything that came from him; and yet he always maintained an amicable correspondence with them, as believing that they acted according to their judgment and conscience, or that their eyes were held by some temptation in the worst of all their oppositions. Indeed, his right works were so many that they exposed him unto the envy of his neighbors; and of such power was that envy that sometimes he could not stand before it; but it was by not standing that he most effectually withstood it all.

Great attempts were sometimes made among the freemen²⁷ to get him left out from his place in the government upon little pretenses, lest by the

25. Plato *Republic* 361C. 4-5 (slightly altered). Citation in Greek deleted.

26. "reputation" in first edition; possibly, an abbreviation or misspelling of "representation."
 27. In New England only the male church-members had the right to vote.
 refer to Luke 6 : 26, Eccles. 4 : 4, and Prov. 27 : 4.

too frequent choice of one man the government should cease to be by choice; and with a particular aim at him, sermons were preached at the Anniversary Court of Election, to dissuade the freemen from choosing one man twice together. This was the reward of his extraordinary serviceableness! But when these attempts did succeed, as they sometimes did, his profound humility appeared in that equality of mind wherewith he applied himself cheerfully to serve the country in whatever station their votes had allotted for him. And one year when the votes came to be numbered, there were found six less for Mr. Winthrop than for another gentleman who then stood in competition. But several other persons regularly tendering their votes before the election was published were, upon a very frivolous objection, refused by some of the magistrates that were afraid lest the election should at last fall upon Mr. Winthrop; which, though it was well perceived, yet such was the self-denial of this patriot that he would not permit any notice to be taken of the injury. But these trials were nothing in comparison of those harsher and harder treats which he sometimes had from the forwardness of not a few in the days of their paroxysms, and from the faction of some against him, not much unlike that of the Piazzis in Florence against the family of the Medici;²⁸ all of which he at last conquered by conforming to the famous judge's motto, *prudens qui patiens*.²⁹ The oracles of God have said "Envy is rottenness to the bones,"³⁰ and Gulielmus Parisiensis³¹ applies it unto rulers, who are as it were the bones of the societies which they belong unto: "Envy," says he, "is often found among them, and it is rottenness unto them." Our Winthrop encountered this envy from others, but conquered it by being free from it himself.

Were it not for the sake of introducing the exemplary skill of this wise man at giving soft answers, one would not choose to relate those instances of wrath which he had sometimes to encounter with; but he was for his gentleness, his forbearance, and his longanimity a pattern so worthy to be

28. In 1478 the Piazzis family assassinated a leading member of the Medici family; the war that resulted came to involve most of Italy.

29. "He who is patient is prudent"; attributed to Edward Coke.

30. From Proverbs 14 : 30. The context of this reference is clearly on Mather's mind through much of his description of Winthrop as magistrate: "In the fear of the Lord is strong confidence: and his children shall have a place of refuge. . . . In the multitude of people is the king's honor: but in the want of people is the destruction of the prince. He that is slow to wrath is of great understanding. . . . A sound heart is the life of the flesh: but envy the rottenness of the bones. He that oppresseth the poor reproacheth his Maker: but he that honoreth him hath mercy on the poor. The wicked is driven away in his wickedness. . . . Righteousness exalteth a nation" (Prov. 14 : 26-34).

31. William of St. Amour (d. 1272), opponent of the Dominican and Franciscan attempt to dictate the curriculum at the University of Paris, and well known as a satirist.

written after that something must here be written of it. He seemed indeed never to speak any other language than that of Theodosius:³² "If any man speak evil of the governor, if it be through lightness, 'tis to be contemned; if it be through madness, 'tis to be pitied; if it be through injury, 'tis to be remitted." Behold, reader, the meekness of wisdom notably exemplified! There was a time when he received a very sharp letter from a gentleman who was a member of the court, but he delivered back the letter unto the messengers that brought it with such a Christian speech as this: "I am not willing to keep such a matter of provocation by me!" Afterwards the same gentleman was compelled by the scarcity of provisions to send unto him that he would sell him some of his cattle, whereupon the governor prayed him to accept what he had sent for as a token of his good will, but the gentleman returned him this answer, "Sir, your overcoming of yourself hath overcome me"; and afterwards gave demonstration of it.

The French have a saying that "*Un honnête homme est un homme mêlé!*" ("a good man is a mixed man"); and there hardly ever was a more sensible mixture of those two things, resolution and condescension,³³ than in this good man. There was a time when the Court of Election being for fear of tumult held at Cambridge, May 17, 1637, the sectarian part of the country, who had the year before gotten a governor more unto their mind, had a project now to have confounded the election, by demanding that the court would consider a petition then tendered before their proceeding thereunto. Mr. Winthrop saw that this was only a trick to throw all into confusion by putting off the choice of the governor and assistants until the day should be over; and therefore he did, with a strenuous resolution, procure a disappointment unto that mischievous and ruinous contrivance. Nevertheless, Mr. Winthrop himself being by the voice of the freemen in this exigency chosen the governor, and all of the other party left out, that ill-affected party discovered the dirt and mire which remained with them after the storm was over; particularly the sergeants, whose office 'twas to attend the governor, laid down their halberds. But such was the condescension of this governor as to take no present notice of this anger and contempt, but only order some of his own servants to take the halberds; and when the country manifested their deep resentments of the affront thus offered him, he prayed them to overlook it. But it was not long before a compensation was made for these things by the doubled respects which were from all parts paid unto him.

Again, there was a time when the suppression of an Antinomian and

32. Theodosius Flavius I (346-395), Christian emperor of Rome. The dispute discussed below concerned Thomas Dudley (1574-1653), a leader of the theocracy; the "messengers" were John Haynes and Thomas Hooker.

33. "disregard of difference of rank or position" (N.E.D.).

Familistical faction³⁴ which extremely threatened the ruin of the country was generally thought much owing unto this renowned man; and therefore when the friends of that faction could not wreak their displeasure on him with any political vexations, they set themselves to do it by ecclesiastical ones. Accordingly, when a sentence of banishment was passed on the ringleaders of those disturbances, who

. . . maria et terras, caelumque profundum
quippe ferant rapidi secum, vertantque per auras,³⁵

many at the church of Boston, who were then that way too much inclined, most earnestly solicited the Elders of that church whereof the governor was a member to call him forth as an offender for passing of that sentence. The Elders were unwilling to do any such thing; but the governor, understanding the ferment among the people, took that occasion to make a speech in the congregation to this effect:

Brethren, understanding that some of you have desired that I should answer for an offence lately taken among you: had I been called upon so to do, I would, first, have advised with the ministers of the country whether the church had power to call in question the civil court; and I would, secondly, have advised with the rest of the court whether I might discover their counsels unto the church. But though I know that the reverend Elders of this church, and some others, do very well apprehend that the church cannot enquire into the proceedings of the court, yet for the satisfaction of the weaker who do not apprehend it, I will declare my mind concerning it. If the church have any such power, they have it from the Lord Jesus Christ; but the Lord Jesus Christ hath disclaimed it, not only by practice, but also by precept, which we have in his Gospel, Matthew 20 : 25-26.³⁶ It is true indeed, that magistrates as they are church-members are accountable unto the church for their failings, but that is when they are out of their calling. When Uzziah would go offer incense in the temple, the

34. The faction was led by Anne Hutchinson (1591-1643). Antinomianism held that the elect stood beyond the moral law as set forth in the Old Testament; Familism, which takes its name from an English sect called the Family of Love (ca. 1570), adhered to a similar doctrine. The electoral dispute of 1637, to which Mather refers above, concerned the Antinomians' support of Sir Henry Vane for governor because of his sympathies for their doctrinal position. Vane returned to England in August, 1637; Anne Hutchinson was banished from Massachusetts the following year.

35. ". . . would, indeed, swiftly bear off with them the sea, the land, and the deep heaven, and turn them about through the air." (*Aeneid* 1. 59-60). Modern readings have *verrant* rather than the seventeenth-century reading *vertant* (i.e., "scour" rather than "turn").

36. "You know that the rulers of the Gentiles lord it over them, and their great men exercise authority over them. It shall not be so among you; but whoever would be great among you must be your servant."

officers of the church called him to an account and withstood him; but when Asa put the prophet in prison, the officers of the church did not call him to an account for that.³⁷ If the magistrate shall in a private way wrong any man, the church may call him to an account for it; but if he be in pursuance of a course of justice, though the thing that he does be unjust, yet he is not accountable for it before the church. As for myself, I did nothing in the causes of any of the brethren but by the advice of the Elders of the church. Moreover, in the oath which I have taken there is this clause: "In all causes wherein you are to give your vote, you shall do as in your judgment and conscience you shall see to be just and for the public good." And I am satisfied, it is most for the glory of God, and the public good, that there has been such a sentence passed; yea, those brethren are so divided from the rest of the country in their opinions and practices that it cannot stand with the public peace for them to continue with us; Abraham saw that Hagar and Ishmael must be sent away.³⁸

By such a speech he marvelously convinced, satisfied, and mollified the uneasy brethren of the church; "*sic cunctus pelagi cecidit fragor.*"³⁹ And after a little patient waiting, the differences all so wore away that the church, merely as a token of respect unto the governor, when he had newly met with some losses in his estate, sent him a present of several hundreds of pounds.

Once more, there was a time when some active spirits among the deputies of the colony, by their endeavors not only to make themselves a court of judicature, but also to take away the negative by which the magistrates might check their votes, had like by over-driving to have run the whole government into something too democratical. And if there were a town in Spain undermined by coneys,⁴⁰ another town in Thrace destroyed by moles, a third in Greece ranversed by frogs, a fourth in Germany subverted by rats, I must on this occasion add that there was a country in America like to be confounded by a swine. A certain stray sow, being found, was claimed by two several persons⁴¹ with a claim so equally maintained on both sides that, after six or seven years hunting the business from one court unto another, it was brought at last into the General Court, where the final determination was that it was impossible to proceed unto any judgment in the case. However, in the debate of this matter, the

37. Uzziah, king of Judah, suffered his attack of leprosy, according to the priests, because of his hidden sins (2 Chron. 26); the incident with Asa and Hanani is in 2 Chron. 16 : 7-10.

38. Gen. 21 : 9-14.

39. "With that, the entire tumult of the sea subsided." (*Amad* 1. 154).

40. Rabbi:-

41

rchant (1595-1656), and the Boston widow Goody Sherman;

negative of the upper house upon the lower in that court was brought upon the stage, and agitated with so hot a zeal that a little more and all had been in the fire. In these agitations the governor was informed that an offence had been taken by some eminent persons at certain passages in a discourse by him written thereabout; whereupon with his usual condescendency, when he next came into the General Court, he made a speech of this import:

I understand that some have taken offence at something that I have lately written; which offence I desire to remove now, and begin this year in a reconciled state with you all. As for the matter of my writing, I had the concurrence of my brethren; it is a point of judgment which is not at my own disposing. I have examined it over and over again, by such light as God has given me from the rules of religion, reason, and custom, and I see no cause to retract any thing of it; wherefore I must enjoy my liberty in that as you do yourselves. But for the manner, this, and all that was blameworthy in it, was wholly my own, and whatsoever I might allege for my own justification therein before men, I waive it, as now setting myself before another Judgment Seat. However⁴² what I wrote was upon great provocation, and to vindicate myself and others from great aspersion, yet that was no sufficient warrant for me to allow any distemper of spirit in myself; and I doubt I have been too prodigal of my brethrens' reputation. I might have maintained my cause without casting any blemish upon others when I made that my conclusion, "And now let religion and sound reason give judgment in the case"; it looked as if I arrogated too much unto myself and too little to others. And when I made that profession that I would maintain what I wrote before all the world, though such words might modestly be spoken, yet I perceive an unbecoming pride of my own heart breathing in them. For these failings I ask pardon both of God and man.

Sic ait et dicto citius tumida aequora placat,
collectasque fugat nubes, solemque reducit.⁴³

This acknowledging disposition in the governor made them all acknowledge that he was truly "a man of an excellent spirit." In fine, the victories of an Alexander, an Hannibal, or a Caesar, over other men, were not so glorious as the victories of this great man over himself, which also at last proved victories over other men.

42. I.e., "although."

43. "So he spoke, and even before he finished speaking he had calmed the swelling sea, put the gathered clouds to rout, and brought back the sun." (*Aeneid* 1. 142-43). The quotation that follows is from Prov. 17 : 27.

But the stormiest of all the trials that ever befell this gentleman was in the year 1645, when he was in title no more than deputy governor of the colony. If the famous Cato were forty-four times called into judgment, but as often acquitted,⁴⁴ let it not be wondered if⁴⁵ our famous Winthrop were one time so. There happening certain seditious and mutinous practices in the town of Hingham,⁴⁶ the deputy governor as legally as prudently interposed his authority for the checking of them. Whereupon there followed such an enchantment upon the minds of the deputies in the General Court that upon a scandalous petition of the delinquents unto them—wherein a pretended invasion made upon the liberties of the people was complained of—the deputy governor was most irregularly called forth unto an ignominious hearing before them in a vast assembly; whereto with a sagacious humility he consented, although he showed them how he might have refused it. The result of that hearing was that, notwithstanding the touchy jealousy of the people about their liberties lay at the bottom of all this prosecution, yet Mr. Winthrop was publicly acquitted and the offenders were severally fined and censured. But Mr. Winthrop, then resuming the place of deputy governor on the bench, saw cause to speak unto “the root of the matter” after this manner:

I shall not now speak anything about the past proceedings of this court, or the persons therein concerned. Only I bless God that I see an issue of this troublesome affair. I am well satisfied that I was publicly accused and that I am now publicly acquitted. But though I am justified before men, yet it may be the Lord hath seen so much amiss in my administrations as calls me to be humbled; and indeed for me to have been thus charged by men is itself a matter of humiliation, whereof I desire to make a right use before the Lord. If Miriam's father spit in her face, she is to be ashamed.⁴⁷ But give me leave before you go to say something that may rectify the opinions of many people, from whence the distempers have risen that have lately prevailed upon the body of this people. The questions that have troubled the country have been about the authority of the magistracy, and the liberty of the people. It is you who have called us unto this office; but

44. Cato (234–149 B.C.) came into frequent conflict with Roman officials because of his attacks on the immorality of men in power.

45. First edition reads “and if.”

46. Directed against the government-appointed captain of the town militia.

47. Num. 12 : 14. Miriam was punished by God for speaking against Moses, her brother; she was subsequently forgiven. The preceding allusion to “the root of the matter” is to Job 19 : 28.

being thus called, we have our authority from God; it is the ordinance of God, and it hath the image of God stamped upon it; and the contempt of it has been vindicated by God with terrible examples of his vengeance. I entreat you to consider that when you choose magistrates, you take them from among yourselves, men subject unto like passions with yourselves. If you see our infirmities, reflect on your own, and you will not be so severe censurers of ours. We count him a good servant who breaks not his covenant. The covenant between us and you is the oath you have taken of us, which is to this purpose: "that we shall govern you and judge your causes according to God's laws and our own, according to our best skill." As for our skill, you must run the hazard of it; and if there be an error, not in the will, but only in the skill, it becomes you to bear it. Nor would I have you to mistake in the point of your own liberty. There is a liberty of corrupt nature, which is affected both by men and beasts, to do what they list; and this liberty is inconsistent with authority, impatient of all restraint; by this liberty *sumus omnes deteriores*,⁴⁸ 'tis the grand enemy of truth and peace, and all the ordinances of God are bent against it. But there is a civil, a moral, a federal liberty, which is the proper end and object of authority; it is a liberty for that only which is just and good; for this liberty you are to stand with the hazard of your very lives; and whatsoever crosses it is not authority but a distemper thereof. This liberty is maintained in a way of subjection to authority; and the authority set over you will in all administrations for your good be quietly submitted unto by all but such as have a disposition to shake off the yoke and lose their true liberty by their murmuring at the honor and power of authority.

The spell that was upon the eyes of the people being thus dissolved, their distorted and enraged notions of things all vanished; and the people would not afterwards entrust the helm of the weather-beaten bark in any other hands but Mr. Winthrop's until he died. Indeed, such was the mixture of distant qualities in him as to make a most admirable temper; and his having a certain greatness of soul, which rendered him grave, generous, courageous, resolved, well-applied, and every way a gentleman in his demeanor, did not hinder him from taking sometimes the old Romans' way to avoid confusions, namely *cedendo*,⁴⁹ or from discouraging some things which are agreeable enough to most that wear the name of gentlemen. Hereof I will give no instances, but only oppose two passages of his life.

48. "We are all the worse." (Terence *Heauton Timorumeus* 3.1).

49. "By yielding [the point]." The reference is possibly to the Roman general Fabius (d.

In the year 1632, the governor, with his pastor Mr. Wilson⁵⁰ and some other gentlemen, to settle a good understanding between the two colonies, traveled as far as Plymouth, more than forty miles, through an howling wilderness, no better accommodated in those early days than the princes that in Solomon's time saw servants on horseback,⁵¹ or than Genus and Species in the old epigram, "going on foot."⁵² The difficulty of the walk was abundantly compensated by the honorable, first reception, and then dismissal, which they found from the rulers of Plymouth, and by the good correspondence thus established between the new colonies, who were like the floating bottles wearing this motto, "Si colidimur, frangimur."⁵³ But there were at this time in Plymouth two ministers⁵⁴ leavened so far with the humors of the rigid separation that they insisted vehemently upon the unlawfulness of calling any unregenerate man by the name of "Goodman Such-an-One,"⁵⁵ until by their indiscreet urging of this whimsy the place began to be disquieted. The wiser people being troubled at these trifles, they took the opportunity of Governor Winthrop's being there to have the thing publicly propounded in the congregation; who in answer thereunto distinguished between a theological and a moral goodness, adding, that when juries were first used in England, it was usual for the crier, after the names of persons fit for that service were called over, to bid them all, "Attend, good men and true"; whence it grew to be a civil custom in the English nation for neighbors living by one another to call one another "Goodman Such-an-One," and it was pity now to make a stir about a civil custom so innocently introduced. And that speech of Mr. Winthrop's put a lasting stop to the little, idle, whimsical conceits then beginning to grow obstreperous.

Nevertheless, there was one civil custom used in (and in few but) the

203 B.C.), known as "Cunctator," "the delayer" (from Ennius's eulogy: "cunctando restitit rem"); or else to Ovid *Ars Amatoria* 2.197.

50. John Wilson (ca. 1591–1667), a leading first-generation minister.

51. Eccles. 10 : 7. Throughout the Renaissance, the Book of Ecclesiastes was ascribed to Solomon; cf. Eccles. 1 : 1.

52. Apparently, a reference to the principles of rhetoric and logic; the proverb itself, a Renaissance commonplace, first appears in the medieval lyric poem, "De Clerico et Puella": "Bettene on fote gon, then wycked hors to ryde."

53. "If we collide, we are smashed." (Motto inscribed on Dutch coins of the period.)

54. Ralph Smith (1590–1661) and Roger Williams (1604?–83); both had come from Salem to Plymouth, where they felt they could more fully put their Separatist convictions into practice. Williams stayed only briefly; Smith remained as Plymouth's first settled minister from 1629 to 1636.

55. I.e., Goodman so-and-so (whatever the particular family name of the individual involved). The usual form of address at Plymouth was "Master" or "Sir." Williams and Smith seem to have attached the status of visible sainthood to the form of "Goodman"—i.e., attributed to it a theological (as distinct from a general legal or "moral") meaning.

English nation, which this gentleman did endeavor to abolish in this country; and that was the usage of drinking to one another. For although by drinking to one another no more is meant than an act of courtesy, when one going to drink does invite another to do so too for the same ends with himself, nevertheless the governor (not altogether unlike to Cleomenes, of whom 'tis reported by Plutarch—"nolenti poculum nunquam prae-buit"⁵⁶) considered the impertinency and insignificancy of this usage, as to any of those ends that are usually pretended for it, and that indeed it ordinarily served for no ends at all, but only to provoke persons unto unseasonable and perhaps unreasonable drinking, and at last produce that abominable health-drinking which the Fathers of old so severely rebuked in the pagans, and which the Papists themselves do condemn when their casuists pronounce it "*Peccatum mortale provocare ad aequales calices, et nefas respondere.*"⁵⁷ Wherefore in his own most hospitable house he left it off, not out of any silly or stingy fancy, but merely that by his example a greater temperance, with liberty of drinking, might be recommended, and sundry inconveniences in drinking avoided. And his example accordingly began to be much followed by the sober people in this country (as it now also begins to be among persons of the highest rank in the English nation itself) until an order of court came to be made against that ceremony in drinking, and then the old wont violently returned, with a *nitimur in vetitum*.⁵⁸

Many were the afflictions of this righteous man! He lost much of his estate in a ship and in an house quickly after his coming to New England, besides the prodigious expense of it in the difficulties of his first coming hither. Afterwards his assiduous application unto the public affairs (wherein "*Ispe se non habuit, postquam respublica eum gubernatorem habere capit*")⁵⁹ made him so much to neglect his own private interests, that an unjust steward ran him £2,500 in debt before he was aware; for the payment whereof he was forced many years before his decease to sell the most of what he had left unto him in the country; albeit by the observable blessing of God upon the posterity of this liberal man his children all of them came to fair estates and lived in good fashion and credit. Moreover, he successively buried three wives, the first of which was the daughter and

56. "He never tempted the reluctant to drink." Citation in Greek deleted. Cleomenes III, who reigned 235–222 B.C., was the last great reformist king of Sparta.

57. "It is a deadly sin to challenge another person to a drinking contest, and impious to accept the challenge."

58. "We reach for that which is forbidden." (Ovid *Amores* 3.4.17).

59. "He could no longer attend to his own possessions after the state possessed him as its governor." The steward was James Luxford. The "afflictions" (above) refer to Ps. 34 : 19.

heiress of Mr. Forth, of Much Stambridge⁶⁰ in Essex, by whom he had "wisdom with an inheritance," and an excellent son. The second was the daughter of Mr. William Clopton, of London,⁶¹ who died with her child within a very little while. The third was the daughter of the truly worshipful Sir John Tyndal, who made it her whole care to please, first God, and then her husband, and by whom he had four sons which survived and honored their father.⁶² And unto all these, the addition of the distempers every now and then raised in the country procured unto him a very singular share of trouble. Yea, so hard was the measure which he found even among pious men, in the temptations of a wilderness, that when the thunder and lightning had smitten a windmill whereof he was owner, some had such things in their heads as publicity to reproach this charitablest of men, as if the voice of the Almighty had rebuked I know not what oppression which they judged him guilty of; which things I would not have mentioned but that the instances may fortify the expectations of my best readers for such afflictions.

He that had been for his attainments, as they said of the blessed Macarius,⁶³ "an old man while a young one," and that had in his young days met with many of those ill days whereof he could say he had little pleasure in them, now found old age in its infirmities advancing earlier upon him than it came upon his much longer-lived progenitors. While he was yet seven years off of that which we call the grand climacterical,⁶⁴ he felt the approaches of his dissolution; and finding he could say,

non habitus, non ipse color non gressus euntis,
non species eadem quae fuit ante manet,⁶⁵

he then wrote this account of himself: "Age now comes upon me, and

60. Also Great Stambridge; Winthrop married Mary Forth (1583-1615) in 1606; of their six children only their son, John (b. 1606), survived the father.

61. Or of Castleine, near Groton; Winthrop married Thomasine Clopton (1583-1616) in 1615. The preceding quotation is from Eccles. 7 : 11.

62. Winthrop married Margaret Tyndal in 1618; their four sons were Steven (b. 1618), Adam (b. 1618), Deane (b. 1622), and Samuel (b. 1627).

63. From Palladius *Historia Lausiaca* 17, 2 (citation in Greek deleted), on the life of Macarius of Egypt, also called Macarius the Great (ca. 300-ca. 390). "Macarius" means blessed and so Mather probably intends the adjective as a pun. Palladius's meaning, which Mather adopts, is that Macarius had accomplished a great deal when he was still a young man.

64. I.e., he was 63 years old. The "grand climacterical" denotes the age of seventy; the number seven has figural significance (as a "holy number") here and throughout the *Magnalia's* seven books.

65. "Neither his bearing, nor even his complexion, nor his step as he walks, nor his overall appearance—nothing remains as it was before" (Maximianus *Elegies* 1.210-11). Regarding Winthrop's speech which follows, see: 2 Tim. 4 : 6, Ps. 31 : 15, 1 Cor. 4 : 2, Matt. 25 : 21-23.

infirmities therewithal, which makes me apprehend that the time of my departure out of this world is not far off. However, our times are all in the Lord's hand, so as we need not trouble our thoughts how long or short they may be, but how we may be found faithful when we are called for." But at last when that year came, he took a cold which turned into a fever whereof he lay sick about a month, and in that sickness—as it hath been observed, that there was allowed unto the serpent the bruising of the heel,⁶⁶ and accordingly at the heel or close of our lives the Old Serpent will be nibbling more than ever in our lives before, and when the Devil sees that we shall shortly be where the wicked cease from troubling,⁶⁷ that wicked one will trouble us more than ever—so this eminent saint now underwent sharp conflicts with the tempter, whose wrath grew great as the time to exert it grew short;⁶⁸ and he was buffeted with the disconsolate thoughts of black and sore desertions, wherein he could use that sad representation of his own condition:

nuper eram judex, jam judicor; ante tribunal
subsistens paveo, judicor ipse modo.⁶⁹

But it was not long before those clouds were dispelled, and he enjoyed in his holy soul the great consolations of God! While he thus lay ripening for heaven, he did out of obedience unto the ordinance of our Lord send for the Elders of the church to pray with him: yea, they and the whole church fasted as well as prayed for him. And in that fast the venerable Cotton⁷⁰ preached on Psalms 35 : 13-14: "When they were sick, I humbled myself with fasting; I behaved myself as though he had been my friend or brother; I bowed down heavily, as one that mourned for his mother." From whence I find him raising that observation, "The sickness of one that is to us as a friend, a brother, a mother, is a just occasion of deep humbling our souls with fasting and prayer," and making this application:

Upon this occasion we are now to attend this duty for a governor who has been to us as a friend in his counsel for all things, and help for our bodies by physic, for our estates by law, and of whom there was no fear of his becoming an enemy, like the friends of David;⁷¹ a governor

66. Gen. 3 : 15, the *protevangelium*, where God tells the snake—Satan, "that old serpent" (Rev. 12 : 9, 20 : 2)—that man "shall bruise thy head and thou shalt bruise his heel."

67. Job 3 : 17.

68. Rev. 12 : 12.

69. "Recently I was a judge, now I am judged; I tremble as I stand before the tribunal, to be judged myself."

70. John Cotton (1584-1652), Cotton Mather's grandfather and namesake.

71. David's appointed counsellors and magistrates who joined with Absalom in his revolt against David (2 Sam. 16).

who has been unto us as a brother: not usurping authority over the church, often speaking his advice, and often contradicted, even by young men, and some of low degree; yet not replying, but offering satisfaction also when any supposed offences have arisen; a governor who has been unto us as a mother, parent-like distributing his goods to brethren and neighbors at his first coming, and gently bearing our infirmities without taking notice of them.

Such a governor, after he had been more than ten several times by the people chosen their governor, was New England now to lose; who, having like Jacob first left his council and blessing with his children gathered about his bedside,⁷² and like David served his generation by the will of God,⁷³ he gave up the ghost and fell asleep on March 26, 1649, having, like the dying emperor Valentinian,⁷⁴ this above all his other victories for his triumphs, his overcoming of himself.

The words of Josephus about Nehemiah, the governor of Israel, we will now use upon this governor of New England, as his

EPITAPH

Vir fuit indole bonus ac justus
et popularium gloriae amantissimus;
quibus eternum reliquit monumentum,
Novanglorum moenia.⁷⁵

72. Gen. 49 : 1-33.

73. Acts 13 : 36.

74. Christian emperor of Rome, d. 375.

75. "By nature he was a man good and just, and most zealous for the glory of his countrymen; he left behind for them an eternal memorial—the walls of New England." The Latin substitutes "New England" for the original Greek "Jerusalem." The passage from Josephus (ca. 37-100) appears, in prose, in his *Antiquities of the Jews*, bk. 11, chap. 5. Citation in Greek deleted.